LET'S UNDERSTAND WHAT READING SCIENCE IS ALL ABOUT

THE SCIENCE OF READING

The body of work referred to as “the science of reading” is not an ideology, a philosophy, a political agenda, a one-size-fits-all approach, a program of instruction, or a specific component of instruction. It is the emerging consensus from many related disciplines, based on literally thousands of studies, supported by hundreds of millions of research dollars, conducted across the world in many languages. These studies have revealed a great deal about how we learn to read, what goes wrong when students don’t learn, and what kind of instruction is most likely to work the best for the most students.

SYSTEMATIC, EXPLICIT & CUMULATIVE

With regard to the importance of teaching phonics systematically, explicitly, and cumulatively, the scientific consensus (see Foorman et al., 2016) is very strong. Most of the studies that show positive effects in comparison to “business as usual” have provided phonics instruction about 30–45 minutes per day, using different instructional materials. Good phonics instruction, moreover, is hands-on and moves from presentation of a concept to practice exercises and then to its direct application in reading and spelling.

NOT LIMITED TO PHONICS

The body of scientific evidence about reading is not limited to the importance of phonics instruction. Perhaps the most critical and least-practiced component of effective early instruction is phoneme awareness. Awareness of the sounds that make up spoken words, facility at manipulating those sounds, and the links between speech and print must be mastered for students to be fluent readers and accurate spellers of an alphabetic writing system like ours.

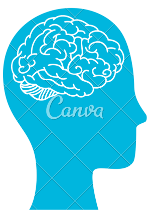
LANGUAGE COMPREHENSION

Reading science has not neglected the importance of language comprehension and the challenges of reading comprehension. While this aspect of reading is more difficult to research than foundational reading skills, we can hang our hat on certain robust findings. They include the critical importance of building vocabulary and background knowledge for text reading, and the value of a content-rich curriculum that is more focused on what the students are learning about than it is on teaching specific comprehension skills (e.g., see Wexler, 2019). Comprehension skills, such as how to find the main idea or how to write a summary, generalize better if they are practiced in the context of learning about a worthwhile topic.

A WELL DESIGNED EARLY READING PROGRAM - PART 1

A well-designed early-reading program would teach these foundational skills explicitly and systematically, with adequate time devoted to each: awareness of speech sounds, segmentation, manipulation of sounds, letter formation and writing by hand, phoneme-grapheme correspondences, spelling patterns, meaningful word parts (morphemes).

A WELL DESIGNED EARLY READING PROGRAM - PART 2



Then, each skill or concept would be applied to phrase, sentence, and passage reading—we hope in the context of learning about something of importance. Then, language comprehension can be nurtured through rich content learning, reading aloud, classroom discussion, and deliberate study of language at the level of sentences, paragraphs, and longer texts. Good instruction is never “regurgitation without comprehension.”

OF ‘HARD WORDS’ AND STRAW MEN: LET’S UNDERSTAND WHAT READING SCIENCE IS REALLY ABOUT, BY DR LOUISA MOATS

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